

N How to Get Your Local Business Recommended by ChatGPT, Gemini & Perplexity (2026 Guide)

How do you get a local business recommended by ChatGPT, Gemini or Perplexity?

Make your business easy for AI tools to find, verify and quote: a complete Google Business Profile, consistent listings, detailed reviews, answer-first website pages with structured data, and mentions on trusted third-party sites.

Nobody outside these companies knows the exact ranking rules, and there is no paid shortcut. But the tactics below match how these tools visibly work: they retrieve web pages, cross-check them and summarise the result. Customers already ask questions like "best GST consultant in Ahmedabad" or "affordable website developer near me" directly to AI assistants. If your business is missing from the answer, you are invisible at the moment of decision. This guide turns that into a practical 30-day plan for Indian local businesses.

Key takeaways

- AI assistants recommend businesses they can **find, verify across sources and quote confidently**.
- Classic local SEO (Google Business Profile, reviews, consistent listings) is still the foundation, especially for Gemini.
- Answer-first pages, structured data and third-party mentions make you **quotable**.
- Let the right crawlers in, then test monthly with a **prompt audit**.
- Treat results as directional: AI answers vary between runs and change over time.

GEO, AEO and local SEO: what is the difference?

- **Local SEO** means ranking in Google Maps and local results for searches with local intent.
- **AEO (Answer Engine Optimisation)** means structuring content so search engines and assistants can lift a direct answer from it.
- **GEO (Generative Engine Optimisation)** means increasing the chance that AI-generated answers mention, cite or recommend your brand.

For a local business the three overlap heavily, and the same trust signals help all of them. For a deeper look at the search side, see our guides on AI search optimization in 2026 and how to rank in Google SGE.

How do ChatGPT, Gemini and Perplexity decide which businesses to recommend?

Each assistant works differently, but all of them lean on some mix of what a model already knows, live web results, and structured business data. Here is what each tends to rely on:

Assistant	Where answers tend to come from	Your priority
ChatGPT	Model knowledge plus live web search when search is used, with links to the pages it drew on	Crawlable website, consistent third-party mentions, strong reviews on major platforms
Gemini	Google's ecosystem: Search index, Business Profile and Maps data	Complete Google Business Profile, reviews and a technically sound website
Perplexity	Live web retrieval with visible source citations	Answer-first pages, authoritative citations and fresh content

These are summaries of observable behaviour, not published ranking formulas. They change as the products change.

Step 1: Build a complete, consistent business profile

Assistants and maps products need to be sure who you are, what you do and where you operate. Start with the basics:

- **Claim and complete your Google Business Profile:** primary and secondary categories, services, service areas, hours, description and real photos.
- **Keep name, address and phone number (NAP) identical** on your website, Google profile, Justdial, Sulekha, IndiaMART, LinkedIn and Facebook.
- **Write one clear sentence about your business and reuse it everywhere.** For example: "Vyaaptam is an Ahmedabad-based agency offering digital marketing, legal consulting and web development."

Our Google Business Profile guide walks through the profile setup step by step.

Step 2: Earn detailed, genuine reviews

Reviews are a strong trust signal, and detailed ones give assistants something specific to quote. "Great service" tells an AI nothing. "They filed our GST registration in a week and explained every document" does.

- Ask right after you deliver, when the experience is fresh.
- Prompt for specifics: "Which service did we help you with, and what changed for you?"
- Reply to every review, positive or negative, in a natural voice.
- Never buy, fake or incentivise reviews. It breaks platform policies and can get your profile suspended.

Step 3: Rewrite key pages to answer questions first

AI tools favour pages that state the answer plainly. Put the direct answer in the first 40–60 words under a question-style heading, then add detail. Compare these two versions:

Version	Example
Before	"We deliver 360° digital solutions with cutting-edge technology for every business."
After	"Digital marketing for a small business in Ahmedabad typically covers SEO, social media, Google Ads and content. Vyaaptam builds a custom plan around your goals, shares regular reports and aims to show measurable results within the first 30 days."

The second version names the service, the place, what is included and what to expect. That is exactly what an assistant can lift into an answer. Apply the same pattern across your key pages:

- Use question-style H2s that match how customers actually ask.
- Add specifics: price ranges, timelines, service areas and process steps.
- Include comparison tables and a short FAQ on each service page.
- Show the author, published date and last-updated date.
- Create location pages only for areas you genuinely serve, and make each one useful rather than a copy with a swapped city name.

Step 4: Add structured data

Structured data (schema markup) labels your business details in a format machines read easily. For a local business, the most useful types are:

- **LocalBusiness** (or a subtype such as ProfessionalService): name, address, phone, hours, service area and social profiles
- **Organization**: brand name, logo and official profiles
- **FAQPage**: questions and answers on service pages
- **Article**: author and dates on blog posts

Here is a LocalBusiness template you can adapt:

```
{
  "@context": "https://schema.org",
  "@type": "ProfessionalService",
  "name": "[Business name]",
  "url": "https://[yourdomain]",
  "logo": "[Logo URL]",
  "image": "[Photo URL]",
  "description": "[One clear sentence: what you do and who for]",
  "telephone": "+91-[number]",
  "address": {
    "@type": "PostalAddress",
    "streetAddress": "[Street address]",
    "addressLocality": "Ahmedabad",
    "addressRegion": "Gujarat",
    "postalCode": "[PIN code]",
    "addressCountry": "IN"
  },
  "areaServed": [
    "Ahmedabad",
    "Gandhinagar"
  ],
  "openingHours": "Mo-Sa [open]-[close]",
}
```

```
"sameAs": [
  "[Google Business Profile link]",
  "[LinkedIn page URL]",
  "[Facebook page URL]",
  "[Instagram profile URL]"
]
```

Structured data helps machines understand your page. It is not a guaranteed switch for rankings or AI citations. Do not mark up reviews you wrote about yourself, as self-serving review markup is not eligible for review rich results.

Step 5: Get mentioned on trusted third-party sites

Assistants that cite sources tend to lean on pages they can corroborate. When several independent sites describe your business the same way, you become easier to trust and easier to recommend. Good places to be listed or mentioned:

- business directories such as Justdial, Sulekha and IndiaMART
- industry platforms that review or rank providers, such as Clutch or GoodFirms for agencies
- local business associations and chambers of commerce
- local news, press mentions, podcasts and guest articles
- an active LinkedIn company page and founder profiles
- honest, disclosed participation in Reddit and Quora discussions

For more on the professional-network side, read our analysis of LinkedIn and AI search.

Step 6: Let the right crawlers in

If a crawler cannot reach your site, the assistant behind it cannot cite you. These are the main ones to know:

Crawler	What it does	Guidance
Googlebot	Crawls for Google Search, which also feeds Google's AI features	Allow
OAI-SearchBot	OpenAI's crawler for ChatGPT search results	Allow if you want to appear in ChatGPT search
ChatGPT-User	Fetches pages when a ChatGPT user's request needs them	Allow
GPTBot	Collects content that may be used to train OpenAI models	Your choice; separate from search appearance
PerplexityBot	Builds Perplexity's search index	Allow
Google-Extended	Controls whether Google may use your content for Gemini AI features; does not affect Search ranking	Your choice

Bot names and behaviour change, so confirm against each provider's current documentation.

Then run through this technical checklist:

1. Open `yourdomain.com/robots.txt` and check nothing blocks the crawlers you want.
2. Check your CDN or firewall settings. Bot protection can silently block legitimate crawlers.
3. Keep key information in HTML text, not only in images, PDFs or content loaded by scripts.
4. Keep pages fast on mobile and avoid login walls on public information.

Step 7: Test with a prompt audit

A prompt audit shows whether assistants recommend you today and what to improve. Ask the same set of questions a customer would ask, in fresh chats, on ChatGPT, Gemini and Perplexity. Sample prompts for an Ahmedabad agency:

- "Best digital marketing agency in Ahmedabad for small businesses"
- "Who can help me register a private limited company in Ahmedabad?"
- "Affordable website development company in Ahmedabad"
- "WordPress or Shopify for a small business in India?"
- "How do I get my business to show up on ChatGPT?"

Log the results in a simple sheet like this:

Prompt	Tool	Mentioned?	Position	Sources cited	Notes
[your prompt]	ChatGPT	Yes / No	#	[URLs]	[competitors seen]
[your prompt]	Gemini	Yes / No	#	[URLs]	
[your prompt]	Perplexity	Yes / No	#	[URLs]	

- Repeat each prompt a few times, because answers vary between runs, and keep the wording the same every month.
- Note which of your pages get cited. Make more of what works.
- In Google Analytics 4, watch referral traffic from sources like `chatgpt.com`, `perplexity.ai` and `gemini.google.com`, and group them into a custom "AI assistants" channel.
- Add "ChatGPT / AI assistant" as an option to your "How did you hear about us?" form field.

Your 30-day action plan

Week	Focus	Actions
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Week 1	Baseline and profile	Run the prompt audit; complete the Google Business Profile; standardise name, address and phone across all listings
Week 2	Reviews and core pages	Start a review-request routine; rewrite 3–5 key service pages answer-first with FAQs
Week 3	Technical	Add structured data; check robots.txt and firewall rules; fix mobile speed issues
Week 4	Authority	Secure 3–5 listings or mentions on trusted third-party sites; publish one question-led article; re-run the audit and compare

Myths that waste time

- **"Add an llms.txt file and AI will recommend you."** It is a proposed convention, and major AI providers have not confirmed it as a ranking signal. Optional at best.
- **"Hide instructions for AI in your page."** Manipulative tactics can backfire and damage trust.
- **"Forget Google."** Gemini and Google's AI features rely on Google's ecosystem, so classic SEO remains the base.
- **"Set it and forget it."** AI answers and sources shift constantly. Refresh key pages and re-audit every quarter.

Frequently asked questions

Can I pay ChatGPT, Gemini or Perplexity to recommend my business?

There is no reliable way to buy an organic recommendation from these assistants. Recommendations are earned through accurate business data, reviews, useful web pages and mentions on trusted sites. Paid ad formats may exist on some platforms, but they are separate from organic answers.

Is GEO different from SEO?

They overlap. SEO focuses on ranking in search results, while GEO (generative engine optimisation) focuses on being mentioned or cited in AI-generated answers. The same foundations help both: clear, accurate, well-structured pages, strong reviews and trusted third-party mentions.

How long does it take to get recommended by AI assistants?

There is no fixed timeline. Changes to a Google Business Profile or website can be picked up within days or weeks, while reviews and third-party mentions build over months. Track progress with a monthly prompt audit rather than expecting overnight results.

Can a small local business compete with big brands in AI answers?

Yes, especially for specific local questions. AI assistants often answer "best X in [city]" with local sources, so a complete profile, detailed reviews and clear service-area pages can outweigh a bigger brand's generic content.

Should I block AI crawlers on my website?

If you want to appear in AI answers, do not block search crawlers such as OAI-SearchBot and PerplexityBot. Training-related crawlers such as GPTBot and Google-Extended are a separate choice. Check each provider's current documentation before deciding.

How do I check if ChatGPT recommends my business?

Run a prompt audit. Ask the questions your customers would ask, such as "best [service] in [city]", in fresh chats on ChatGPT, Gemini and Perplexity. Record whether your business is mentioned, its position and the sources cited, then repeat monthly.